Beyond the flags stood a huge building, one of the ugliest I'd ever seen. A windowless box, built by the Americans as a research center. The architect who designed this monstrosity, I thought, must've been filled with hate for his fellow humans, for the planet, for the Pole. It broke my heart to see a thing so unsightly dominate a land so otherwise pristine. Nevertheless, along with everyone else, I hurried inside the ugly building to warm up, have a pee, drink some cocoa.

There was a huge café and we were all starving. Sorry, we were told, café's closed. *Would you like a glass of water?*

Water? Oh. OK.

Each of us was handed a glass.

Then a souvenir. A test tube.

With a tiny cork in the top.

On the side was a printed label: CLEANEST AIR IN THE WORLD.

69.

I WENT DIRECTLY FROM the South Pole to Sandringham.

Christmas with the family.

Hotel Granny was full that year, overrun by family, so I was given a mini room in a narrow back corridor, among the offices of Palace staff. I'd never stayed there before. I'd rarely even set foot there before. (Not so unusual; all Granny's residences are vast—it would take a lifetime to see every nook and cranny.) I liked the notion of seeing and exploring uncharted territory—I was a grizzled polar explorer, after all!—but I also felt a bit unappreciated. A bit unloved. Relegated to the hinterlands.

I told myself to make the best of it, use this time to protect the serenity I'd achieved at the Pole. My hard drive was cleaned.

Alas, my family at that moment was infected with some very scary malware.